

ALL EYES ON BHARAT
PM Modi addresses a joint meeting of the US Congress in Washington, June 22

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One thing Assam CM Himanta Biswa Sarma has learned is to take notes whenever the PM meets him, for he knows that in the next meeting, Modi would reel out all the points and enquire about the progress made

5.8 per cent in 2018-19 to 3.2 per cent in 2022-23. Labour force participation rates have increased from 50.2 per cent in 2019-20 to 57.9 per cent in 2022-23. As for inflation rates, he quotes figures to say that average inflation from 2014-15 to 2023-24 (up to November) was 5.1 per cent compared to 8.2 per cent during the previous 10 years when the UPA ruled.

The Opposition, though, opines that India's economic growth is K-shaped, meaning that the upper middle class and rich have seen their incomes rise while that of the poor have crashed. They claim the fact that every party, including the BJP, was offering freebies to win votes in the recent round of assembly elections was a sign of the silent rural distress. Economists also argue that it is not the quantity of jobs but the quality that is a cause of worry. This was because most of the growth has come from the self-employed sector rather than the formal economy and that the percentage of unpaid workers (for example, those who tilled their fields) was high.

There is also criticism that Modi has moved from being the federalist when he was Gujarat CM, to becoming "80 per cent unitarist" in his approach; this has resulted in over-centralisation of decision-making in the hands of the PMO. From the outsider he was when he came to power in Delhi, Modi, his critics say, has become the ultimate insider now. Others say he has become like a banyan tree that lets nothing grow under it. Modi had some glaring blind spots in 2023, especially his inexplicable reticence over the bloodshed in Manipur and over the suspension of 146 MPs in Parliament. There were also electoral setbacks in Telangana and Karnataka that saw the BJP draw a power blank in the South.

THE VISIONARY

Meanwhile, his latest avatar is that of Modi the Visionary. While everyone is focused on the next general election, Modi is focusing on the next generation. In the interview, he talked about the generation of Indians between 1922 and 1947 who believed that freedom was their birthright and wanted to contribute towards achieving it. Now, he said, there is an *amrit kaal* period again where the next generation believes that India, between now and 2047, will become a truly developed country, a Viksit Bharat. "That aspiration will drive the country to achieve the goal," he felt.

Modi is clear that the traditional definition of a developed nation—of those having a high per capita income, world-class infrastructure and democratic governance—is too limiting for India. Instead he says he would focus on three major priorities. The first would